

Teaching Tech Together

Learner Personas



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Estimated time: 40 minutes.

All art from openclipart.org (open license)

Learning Objectives

1. Explain what learner personas are and what purpose they serve.
2. Describe the four elements every learner persona should have.
3. Create learner personas.
4. Summarize lessons in ways that will appeal to specific learner personas.

Meet Jeri: General Background



- Born and raised in Trinidad
- Moved to Canada to do a PhD in genetics
- Enjoys skating, but still doesn't like the cold

This is Jeri's general background - just a few facts that help to personalize her.

Meet Jeri: Starting Point



- Has been analyzing data with Excel for almost ten years
- Did an intensive one-day workshop in R at a conference
- Tried to learn Git on her own once, found it frustrating

This is where Jeri is now. It's not a list of keywords, because a phrase like "basic knowledge of R" means very different things to different people. Instead, it's written as a description of a particular person, and we trust the reader to interpolate all the information that isn't there.

Meet Jeri: Needs



- Is going to run 300 experiments in the next six months
- Doesn't want to have to do all the analyses by hand
- And wants nicer charts for her thesis than she can produce in Excel

This is what Jeri thinks she wants to learn. The most important thing about this list is that it's written from her point of view: it is what *you*, the more knowledgeable instructor, might know she needs; it's what *she*, with the knowledge she has right now, is searching for.

Meet Jeri: Special Considerations



- Very uncomfortable speaking in front of groups

The final part of the persona describes anything else that ought to be taken into consideration. Are they hard of hearing? Do they need to be away at 4:00 pm for childcare or elder care? Are they going to be using a locked-down machine that won't let them install software packages? Any one of these things could throw your teaching off track, so it's best to think about them up front.

Learner Personas

1. General background
2. Relevant experience
3. Their perceived needs
4. Special considerations



What we just created is called a *learner persona*. Anyone who teaches, or any group that teaches together, should create a handful of these that describe the range of learners they're trying to help. Personas will remind you of one of the most important rules of teaching: *you are not your learners*.

Explain In *Their* Terms



“This one-week hands-on introduction to the tidyverse will show learners how to load, clean, explore, visualize, and analyze tabular data in a reproducible way.”

Once you know who you’re trying to help, you can figure out how your training is going to help them meet their needs and how to explain that *in a way that they can understand*. It’s the one-line entry in the course catalog that will catch their eye and help them figure out whether your training is right for them.

Personas

Anya Academic	Professor; needs training for research and to pass on to students.
Exton Excel	Proficient Excel user who wants to switch to R.
Jacqui Ofalltrades	Data science generalist at a small consulting company.
Larry Legacy	Reluctant learner: would rather keep using the tools he knows.
M'shelle Manager	Manager; makes decisions about tools and training.
Nang Newbie	Undergrad without stats, programming, or real-world experience.
Toshi Techsupport	Sys admin who has to support data scientists.

<https://third-bit.com/learner-personas/>

Here are seven learner personas from <https://third-bit.com/learner-personas/>.

Exercise

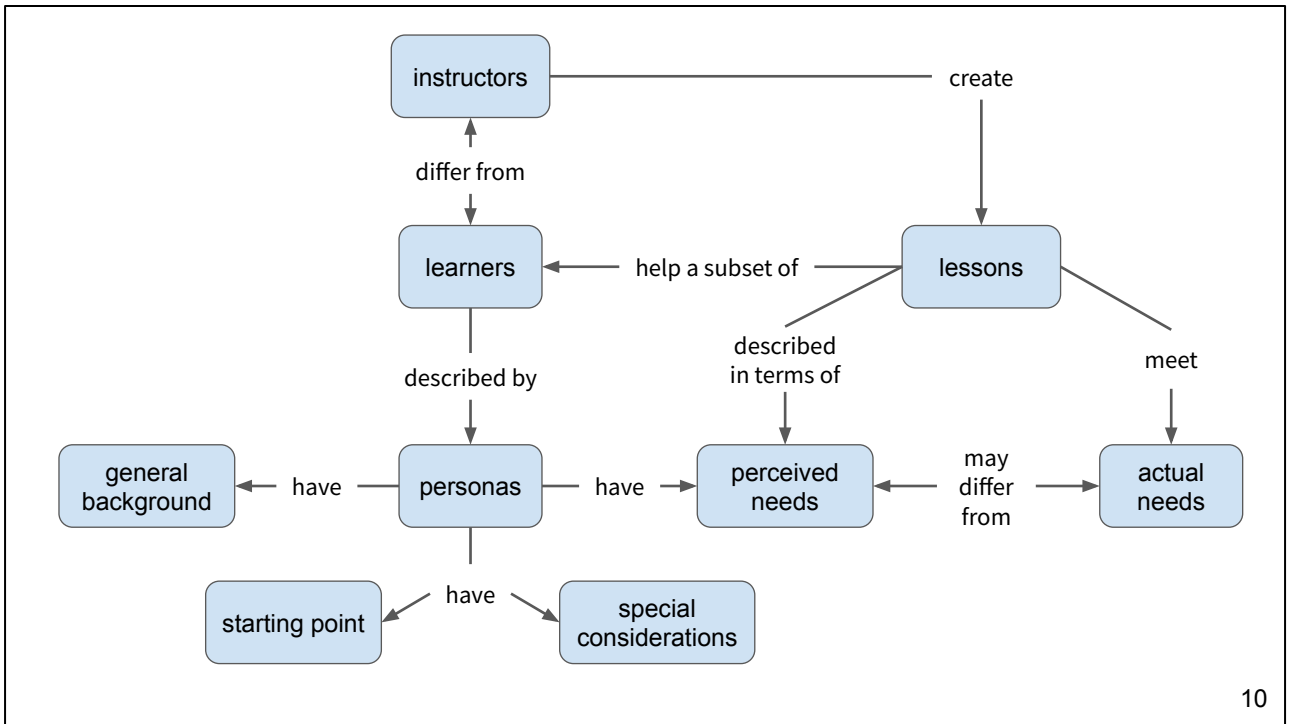
Create a learner persona with:

1. General background
2. Starting point
3. Needs
4. Special considerations

and explain how you can help them.



As an exercise, pair up and create a four-part learner persona and explain how your training will help that person, then share it with the class.



Concept map for personas.

Descriptive text: a graph with nine nodes and ten arcs summarizing the connections between the ideas in this lecture. FIXME: add more descriptive text.